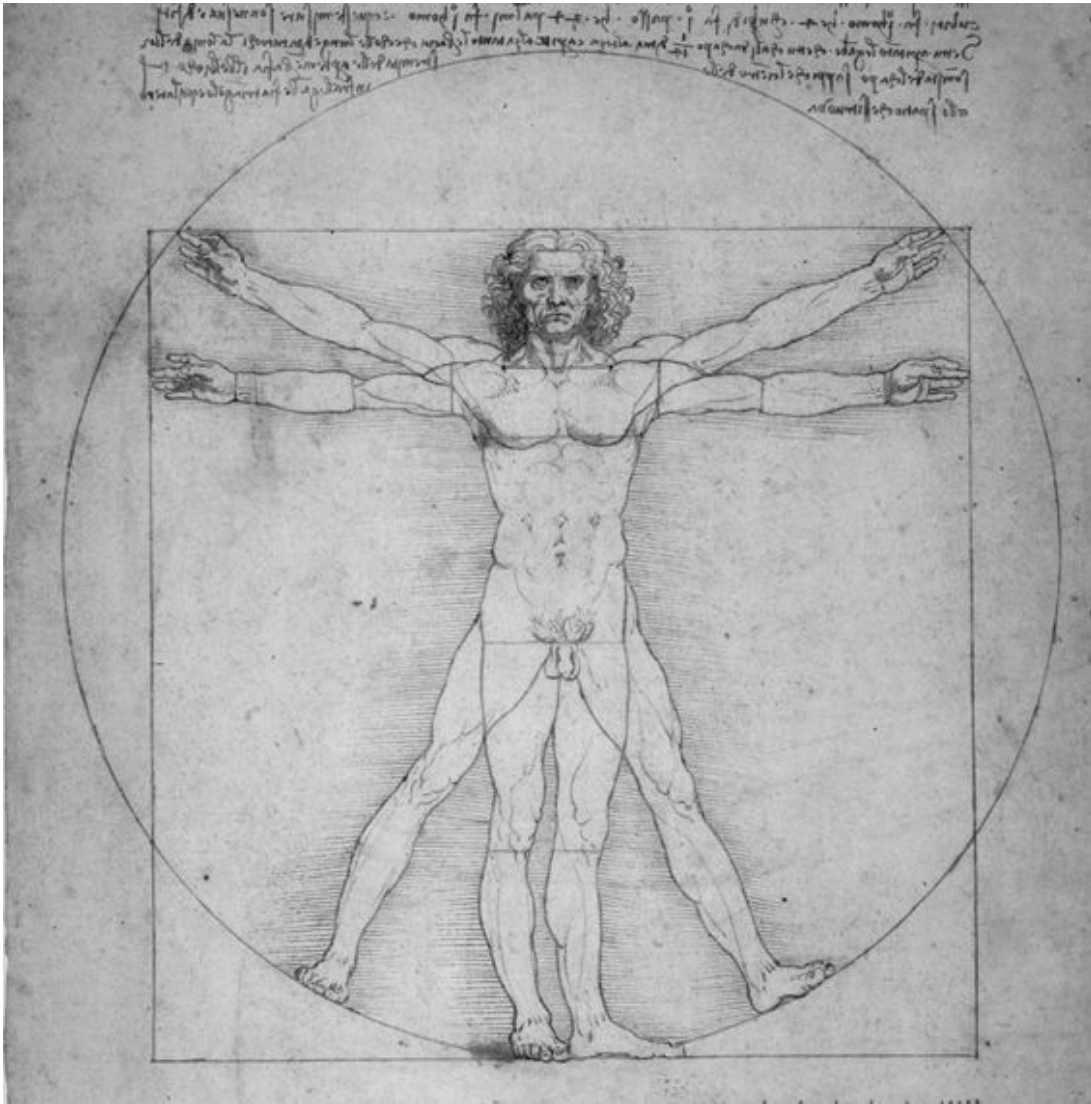


Renaissance humanism



Beginning in 14th-century Florence, the Renaissance was a ‘rebirth’ of classical Greek and Latin culture in Europe after more than a millennium of dominance by the Catholic Church. Prompted by the rediscovery of classical texts, the movement placed humans rather than God at the centre of attention. While Copernicus, Galileo and Kepler attempted to understand the structure of the universe (harking back to the concerns of the first philosophers), Vesalius and Leonardo da Vinci examined human anatomy in meticulous detail. The Renaissance was primarily a cultural and artistic movement, but its emphasis on humanism influenced political thought and

was reflected in the foundation of republics such as Florence and Venice. Here, Renaissance ideals flourished, aided by the invention of printing and the trade that replaced medieval feudalism. Humanism had enormous influence on later philosophy but, with the notable exception of political philosophers such as Machiavelli and reformers in the Church, it was science, not philosophy, that took centre stage at the time.